



*Cooksonia, one of the first upright plants, appeared 425 million years ago. It was just 4 in (10 cm) tall and could support itself with branching stems.*

### Land plants spread out

When plants such as *Cooksonia* evolved sturdier stems, plants began to grow taller and spread farther across land. Later, plants evolved the ability to produce seeds, which can sprout in much drier places than spores. Dense forests then sprang up, turning the land green.



### Early seeds

This plant may look as if it's producing fruits, but actually it is bearing seeds, each the size of an egg. *Medullosa* was the size of a small tree. It appeared about 350 million years ago.



### A helping hand

As forests flourished, plants began to compete to reach the light. Woody stems evolved, allowing plants to reach higher. Plants similar to those we know today began to appear. Tree ferns, for instance, would have been familiar to the dinosaurs.



### Conifer forests

During the dinosaur era, forests were dominated by towering conifer trees. These have thin, needlelike leaves, which cope well with hot, dry climates. The monkey puzzle tree is a type of conifer that still survives from this period.

▼ **WILLIAMSONIA** *These stocky trees would have been familiar to Jurassic and Cretaceous dinosaurs throughout the world. This plant had flowerlike parts. Learn more about the emergence of flowers on pages 224–225.*

